



Clare of Assisi: The Girl Who Chose to Own Nothing

WisdomForge Booklet — Ages 5–10

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About This Book

Clare Offreduccio was born on July 16, 1194, in a stone house on a hill in Assisi, in Italy. Her father, Favorino, was a knight. Her mother, Ortolana, was also from a high family. They had good food, fine clothes, and plans for Clare to marry a nobleman. When she was eighteen she left that house at night, walked to a tiny chapel outside the walls, and let Francis cut her hair. She became a poor woman on purpose.

This booklet tells six stories from her life. Each one has a story, words she really wrote (or words her sisters wrote down soon after), a big idea, something to try, and a question to ask a grown-up. The questions are not tests. They are doors.

She also wrote letters to a princess named Agnes who lived far away in Prague. They never met. For nineteen years they only wrote. In those letters Clare taught a way of looking she called a mirror. You will meet that mirror in Chapter 4. You do not need to be a princess, or a nun, to try looking steadily.

Clare loved God. She loved Jesus. She loved the sisters who lived with her at a place called San Damiano. She fought for forty years so they could own nothing — not even as a group. That is a strange fight. Most people fight to get more. Clare fought for the right to have less.

This book will not pretend she was a quiet doll in a pretty picture. She was shrewd. She clung to an altar. She wrote letters. She held a small box of bread at a gate when soldiers came. She kissed a paper on her deathbed. Keep the real Clare, not a cartoon.

Six chapters, same spine as the older bands will use: the night she left; the right to own nothing; the quiet house; look-think-love-copy; the small box at the gate; the paper she kissed. If a grown-up reads the high booklet later, the names will match. The words will be harder. The woman is the same.

Francis's booklet is already in the house. Clare is not a second verse of his bird song. Read her as her own.

One more grown-up fact a child can hold: a pope who liked Clare still tried to let her own things “for safety.” She said no. That no lasted until two days before she died. The paper she kissed was the no, written down so the next pope could not pretend he had not heard it.

Agnes of Prague had even turned down a marriage to Emperor Frederick II — the same emperor whose soldiers later came near Assisi. Clare wrote to that princess as a sister, not as a fan. Keep both names: Clare of the night walk, Agnes of the letters. They never shared a table. They shared a Rule’s dream.

Chapter 1: The Night She Left



Illustration for Chapter 1

Clare Offreduccio was a noble daughter. That means her father, Favorino Scifi, was a knight. Her mother, Ortolana, was also from a high family. They lived in the upper town, near the fortress. Down the hill lived merchants and makers. Francis, the man who

preached in the streets, was a merchant's son. Clare was from the other class. The Franciscan family crossed that line from the beginning.

Ortolana was already a serious believer. She had gone on long trips to pray in Rome, at Compostela in Spain, and in the Holy Land. Those trips cost money. Piety in a noble house could travel. Clare's seriousness — fasting, giving food to the poor — did not, by itself, cancel a wedding. The family still needed a marriage for land and friends.

People expected Clare to marry. That was how noble families kept land and friends. Clare had been serious since she was small. She gave food to the poor. She fasted. She also had a house, a name, and a future that other people had already drawn.

She heard Francis preach. He did not only talk about poverty. He lived it. For Clare that living was the argument. She met him in secret. The plan was careful, not a tantrum.

On the night after Palm Sunday, March 18, 1212, she slipped out. A door had been blocked with stones and wood — her family may already have guessed. She walked through Assisi in the dark to the Porziuncola, a little chapel outside the walls. There Francis cut her hair. He gave her a rough tunic and a veil. Hair on the floor is not a movie trick. In that world, a shorn head meant she was set apart. She could not be forced into marriage the same way.

The next day uncles and armed relatives came to take her back. Clare clung to the altar and showed her cut hair. The family was furious. Her sister Agnes came soon after. The family tried to drag Agnes home by the hair. Later stories say Agnes became too heavy to lift. That part may be extra. What we can say without guessing: the family used force, and the women did not go back.

Clare was eighteen. She did not become a mascot. She became a poor woman with a legal fact on her head.

Her mother later joined the same life. That matters. The house Clare left was not a cartoon villain house. Ortolana was pious. She had even gone on long pilgrimages. Clare's no was not "my family is wicked." It was "this marriage market is not my life." A child can understand a hard no without needing a wicked stepmother.

Assisi itself was a tense town: nobles up the hill, merchants down it. Francis crossed that line from below. Clare crossed it from above. When they stood in the same little chapel, two kinds of leaving met. Neither leaving was a game.

Words to Remember

"The Son of God has been made for us the Way."

— Clare, **Testament**

Plain English: Clare thought following Jesus was a path you walk, not a pretty idea you keep in a box.

Big Idea

Clare left a rich house on purpose. The haircut was not a costume. It was a choice that changed what other people could make her do.

Try This

1. Draw two houses on a hill: one with fine cloth, one with a small chapel. Draw a path between them at night. Write one word on the path: *choice*. 2. With a grown-up, talk about a time someone in your family changed a plan other people had made for them. 3. Fold a paper door. On one side write “expected.” On the other write “chosen.” Do not pretend they are the same door.

Ask a Grown-Up

When is leaving a family plan brave, and when is it unwise — and who gets to say?

Chapter 2: The Right to Own Nothing



Illustration for Chapter 2

Most rules for nuns were written by men. Clare spent most of her grown life trying to get a Rule of her own — a paper the pope would sign that said her sisters could own nothing, not even together.

Francis's poverty looked like walking: no bag, preach, keep moving. Clare's poverty looked like staying: empty the house so God has room. Same Gospel. Different job. A pope who liked her still offered to let her off the hardest poverty "for safety." She said no. That no is in her *Testament*, the paper she wrote so later bishops could not pretend they had not heard it.

Without a Rule, a community could be closed or folded into another group. Cardinal Hugolino (later Pope Gregory IX) gave women's houses a Rule based on Benedict's, which allowed property. Clare would not take that as the last word. She petitioned popes for years. In 1247 Innocent IV approved a Rule that let them hold property in trust. Clare refused it.

On August 9, 1253, two days before she died, Innocent IV approved the Rule she had written, with the Privilege of Poverty in it. She kissed the document and held it. She died on August 11.

The Rule says the sisters are to live the holy Gospel in obedience, without anything of their own, and in chastity. It says they are not to receive possessions "either in themselves or through others." That means not as a trick either.

Poverty, for Clare, was not a sulk. She thought things you own also own you: you must guard them, count them, fight over them. She wanted her sisters free to pray and to care for the sick. The cloister was not a jail in her mind. It was a quiet room for deep work.

This booklet will not tell you that every poor person is holy, or that every rich person is bad. Clare's fight was specific: her community's legal right to own nothing, because she believed the Gospel asked that of them.

Think of a club that cannot buy a building. Every year someone says, "Just take the land in a friend's name. It is safer." Clare kept saying no to the safer paper. That no took decades. Popes she knew by name still offered the safer paper. She died holding the harder one.

The sisters still ate. They still wore clothes. Alms and handwork kept the house. "Own nothing" did not mean "starve for show." It meant: we will not become landlords. The difference is easy to smear. Keep it clean.

Words to Remember

"I, Clare... promise to the Lord to observe the life and Rule of the Poor Sisters."

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*— opening of Clare's *Rule* (1253), in her own voice as the one who promises*

Plain English: She did not hide behind a man's signature. She promised in her own name.

“O happy poverty, which bestows on those who embrace and love it, the riches of eternal wisdom!”

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— Clare, **Second Letter to Agnes of Prague** (1235)

Plain English: She thought having less could make room for something better than stuff. She did not mean every hungry person is lucky. She meant *this* chosen emptiness.

Big Idea

Clare fought forty years for a paper that said: we may own nothing. That is the opposite of a treasure hunt.

Try This

1. Put three toys in a box labeled “ours.” Put three in a box labeled “not ours.” Which box is harder to stop thinking about? 2. For one afternoon, pick one thing you will not grab back if a sibling uses it. Notice the feeling. It is not a forever vow. It is a tiny practice. 3. Draw a small paper. Write on it “Privilege of Poverty.” Ask a grown-up what a privilege usually means, and why Clare used that word for having less.

Ask a Grown-Up

Can owning nothing be a kind of freedom — and when is it just being in need?

Chapter 3: The Quiet House



Illustration for Chapter 3

After the Porziuncola, Clare's community lived at San Damiano, the little church Francis had repaired. The sisters did not go out to preach in the streets the way the brothers did. They stayed. They prayed the hours — morning, noon, evening, night — the same psalms, the same sisters. They worked with their hands. They cared for sisters who were sick. Clare

herself was often ill. The Rule says serve the sick “as they would wish to be served.” She wrote that because she had been the one in the bed.

Enclosure sounds like a lock. Clare wrote about it as the space where attention can last. The world was not called evil. It was noisy. She thought deep looking needed fewer knocks on the door.

Silence in her Rule is not “never speak.” It is “speak what the life needs.” Correction is to be done with charity. The sick are to be served “as they would wish to be served.” Clare had been sick enough to know that a hard Rule that crushes bodies is not holiness. She put humane limits on fasting.

People sometimes tell Clare’s story as if she only copied Francis. She did love him. She also ran a house for forty years after he died, wrote letters, and won a Rule he never wrote for the women. She called herself a “little plant” of Francis. A plant still has its own roots.

If your house is loud, you already know why a quiet room can be a gift. If your house is lonely, you already know why a quiet room can hurt. Clare’s cloister was a community, not a cave. That difference matters.

The hours of prayer were a clock, not a mood. Morning, noon, evening, night — the same psalms, the same sisters. Manual work sat next to prayer so the body had a job. When a sister was ill, the Rule said serve her as you would wish to be served. Clare wrote that because she had been the one in the bed.

People like to paint enclosed women as locked up against their will. Clare chose the lock as a tool. That does not make every lock holy. It makes *this* lock a choice. Children can hold both: some quiet is love, some quiet is control. Clare’s letters argue for the first.

Words to Remember

“Place your mind before the mirror of eternity.”

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— Clare, **Third Letter to Agnes of Prague**

Plain English: She wanted Agnes to look at Christ the way you look in a mirror — steadily — not to glance and run.

Big Idea

Clare’s quiet was not emptiness. It was a way of paying attention together, with work, prayer, and care for sick bodies.

Try This

1. Sit still for two minutes with a grown-up timer. No talking. Afterward, say one thing you noticed that you usually miss. 2. Draw San Damiano as a small stone house with a door. Inside, draw a bowl, a bed for someone sick, and a lamp. No gold throne. 3. Practice one kind sentence of correction: “I felt __ when __. Next time could we __?” That is closer to Clare’s chapter on correction than a yell.

Ask a Grown-Up

When does quiet help a family, and when is it just shutting someone out?

Chapter 4: Look, Think, Love, Copy



Illustration for Chapter 4

Clare wrote letters to Agnes of Prague, a princess who also chose this poor life. In those letters Clare taught a way of seeing she called a mirror.

Gaze. Consider. Contemplate. Imitate.

First you look. Then you think about what you saw. Then you stay with it until it goes deeper than a glance. Then you try to live it.

Clare wrote this to Agnes of Prague, a princess who also chose the poor life. They never sat in the same room. The letters went over the mountains from Assisi to Prague for nineteen years (1234–1253). Agnes’s letters are lost. We hear Clare answering. That is enough to learn the four verbs. Clare was not asking Agnes to worship a looking-glass. She was asking her to look at Christ — poor, humble, on the cross — until love learned the shape.

This is hard to explain to a child without turning it into a stare contest. Try this instead: you cannot become kind by hearing the word “kind” once. You become kind by watching kind people and practicing. Clare thought Jesus was the person to watch.

She also loved the Eucharist — the bread Christians call Christ’s body. For Clare that was not a magic show. It was the center of the house: God close enough to hold. Later pictures show her with a big golden monstrance. In 1240 she more likely held a small pyx, a simple box. Poor container. Same claim: God is here.

This booklet will not make you take communion. It will not pretend every Christian agrees about the bread. It will tell you what Clare believed she was holding, because that is her story.

Agnes of Prague was a princess. Clare wrote to her as a sister, not as a fan. The letters are how we hear Clare teaching, not only Clare being painted. “Look. Think. Stay. Copy.” Four verbs. They fit a child who is learning anything hard — a hymn, a letter, a kind habit — not only a nun.

If looking is only a glance, nothing copies. If looking never becomes trying, it is only staring. Clare would not let Agnes stop at pretty thoughts.

Words to Remember

“Place your mind before the mirror of eternity! Place your soul in the brilliance of glory! Place your heart in the figure of that divine reality!”

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— Clare, **First Letter to Agnes of Prague** (1234)

Plain English: Look at Christ with your whole attention — mind, soul, heart — not with a quick glance.

“Look at that mirror each day... and continually study your face in it.”

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— Clare, **Fourth Letter to Agnes of Prague** (1253)

Plain English: Do not look once. Look again. Let the looking change your face.

“What you hold, may you always hold. What you do, may you always do. What you pursue, may you always pursue. May you go forward securely, joyfully, and swiftly, on the path of prudent happiness.”

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— Clare, **Third Letter to Agnes of Prague**

Plain English: Keep going. Joy can be careful, not silly. Clare called it prudent happiness.

Big Idea

Clare’s “mirror” is a practice: look until love has something to copy. It is not a selfie.

Try This

1. Look at one ordinary object for a full minute (a cup, a leaf, a shoe). Then draw it from memory. Notice what you skipped. 2. Make four cards: Look / Think / Stay / Try. Use them once this week on a kind act you saw. 3. If your family prays, sit still for one Our Father without rushing. If not, sit still for one slow song.

Ask a Grown-Up

Who do we copy without noticing — and who would Clare want us to copy instead?

Chapter 5: The Small Box at the Gate



Illustration for Chapter 5

In September 1240, soldiers — Saracen mercenaries working for Emperor Frederick II — came near Assisi. Clare's sisters later told the story for her canonization. Clare was sick in bed. She asked to be carried to the door of the cloister. She held up the Eucharist in a pyx and prayed that her sisters would be kept safe. The soldiers left.

Two years later, in 1242, another force came. The sisters prayed. The attackers withdrew again. Two stories. Same center: the bread she believed was Christ.

We cannot prove from a lab what made the men leave. Maybe a miracle. Maybe they had other orders. Maybe a sick woman with a holy object unnerved them. Honest books leave the mechanism open. The sisters experienced it as an answer to the Presence they believed was in the bread.

Later art put a big gold monstrance in her hands. That vessel was not the common tool in 1240. A pyx is small. Clare's poverty and her theology match the small box better than the parade object.

She did not swing a sword. She did not hide under the bed. She went to the door. That is a third way: not fighting, not vanishing.

Frederick II's war was a grown-up mess of emperors and popes. The sisters were not an army. Looters look for easy rooms. A convent can look easy. Clare made the door a place of prayer, not a place of screaming. Whether God turned the men or the men simply left, her sisters remembered the pyx, not a speech.

If you are ever in real danger, you find a grown-up and you get to safety. This chapter is Clare's story, not a drill for children to stand in a driveway. The lesson you *can* keep: she used what she trusted, and she did not pretend a golden statue was in her hands.

Words to Remember

The sisters' testimony is action more than a slogan. Clare's own letters still teach the same center:

"May you cling to His most sweet Mother."

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— Clare, **Third Letter to Agnes**

Plain English: She pointed friends to Jesus and to Mary, not to panic. At the gate she pointed to the bread she believed was Christ.

Big Idea

Clare met danger with the thing she trusted most — not with a weapon and not with pretend bravery. We do not have to settle *how* the soldiers left to hear what she thought was strongest.

Try This

1. Draw two pictures: a giant gold stand, and a small wooden box. Label which one fits 1240. Label which one later painters liked. 2. Practice a “third way” with toys: not hitting, not running away — standing and speaking one calm sentence. 3. If someone in your house is sick, do one small care (water, blanket, quiet). Clare’s Rule said tend the body.

Ask a Grown-Up

When is standing still in danger brave, and when do we need to run and get help?

Chapter 6: The Paper She Kissed



Illustration for Chapter 6

Clare's body was tired for years. She still governed. She still wrote. She still refused Rules that let the house own things.

On August 9, 1253, the approved Rule arrived (the papal paper is called *Solet Annus*). She kissed it. She died August 11. The Church later named her a saint. Canonization is a church process. It does not magically make every later painting true. It does mean people close to her thought her life was worth copying.

After she died, the Rule was changed more than once. Poor Clares today live under more than one version. The fight for her paper did not end at her bed. That is sad and ordinary. Papers get edited. Clare's kiss still says: this version, this poverty, this house.

Francis had died in 1226. Clare outlived him by twenty-seven years. She is not a footnote to his bird pictures. She is the woman who kept a poor women's house standing, and who wrote the first Rule by a woman for women in the Western Church.

You do not have to become a nun to learn from her. You can learn: a choice can be both passionate and planned. Quiet can be work. Owning less can be a fight. A small box can be the center of a life. A dying woman can still sign her name to a paper.

The calendar: born 1194, left 1212, Francis died 1226, Clare died 1253. Forty years in one house. That is longer than a child's whole life so far. The kiss at the end is not a fairy-tale stamp. It is a tired woman glad the words finally matched the life.

After her, painters loved the gold monstrance. Keep the small box. Keep the night walk. Keep the forty-year no. That is enough Clare for a first booklet.

Words to Remember

"May whoever observes these things be filled in heaven with the blessing of the most high Father."

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— Clare, **Blessing**

Plain English: She blessed the sisters who would keep the life, not the ones who would merely talk about it.

Big Idea

Clare finished the way she started: she held a paper that matched her life. The kiss was not magic. It was gladness that the words were finally allowed.

Try This

1. Make a six-box comic: night leaving, shorn hair, quiet house, mirror letters, pyx at the gate, kiss the Rule. One sentence under each. 2. Write a one-line blessing for someone, like

Clare's, and give it. No fake-old language required. 3. With a grown-up, look up San Damiano on a map of Assisi. Put a finger on the hill. Remember it is a real place.

Ask a Grown-Up

What paper in our family would we kiss if we finally got the wording right — a rule, a promise, a will — and why?

For the Grown-Up Reader

Stories follow Clare's *Rule* (1253), *Testament*, *Blessing*, and the *Letters to Agnes of Prague*, as commonly read in Armstrong and Brady, *Francis and Clare: The Complete Works* (Paulist, 1982). Joan Mueller, *Clare's Letters to Agnes* (2001), is the letter companion. The Palm Sunday flight, the family's force, the 1240 gate, and the deathbed Rule are in the *Acts of the Process of Canonization* (1253–1255) and the *Legend of St. Clare* (1255). Modern checks: Joan Mueller, *A Companion to Clare of Assisi* (2010); Catherine M. Mooney, *Clare of Assisi and the Thirteenth-Century Church* (2018). Innocent IV's approval of the Rule is *Solet Annus* (9 August 1253).

Little-band edges: pyx not monstrance; mechanism of the soldiers' retreat left open; no Peace Prayer (not Clare); no claim that poverty is for every household; theological humility — we teach her argument, not a required conclusion. Agnes's "too heavy to lift" is labeled as later color.

Did she really write these things? The Rule, Testament, Blessing, and Agnes letters are hers (authorship debates on some letters wait for older bands). Canonization testimony is early and not a lab.

Little-band chronology to keep straight: Palm Sunday night 1212; San Damiano as the house; Hugolino's imposed Rule vs Clare's own; Innocent IV's 1247 compromise refused; 1240 pyx at the gate (not a monstrance); Rule approved 9 August 1253; death 11 August 1253. Ortolana and Agnes belong in the family story. Francis is a partner, not the author of her Rule.

If a child asks "was she a feminist?" say: she wrote the first Rule by a woman for women. She was not writing a modern essay about rights. Both can be true. If they ask "should we own nothing?" say: that was her community's vow, not a law for your kitchen. If they ask "did the soldiers run because of a miracle?" say: her sisters thought so; we were not there; we can still tell the pyx honestly.

Mooney's book is the best check on the forty-year legal fight. Mueller is the companion for writings and spirituality. Celano is early Francis, not a Clare camera. Wikipedia is not a source for quotes.

About WisdomForge

WisdomForge produces four age-adapted booklets for each figure: elementary (ages 5–10), middle (ages 11–14), high (ages 15–18), and adult. Each booklet covers the same person, ideas, and stories, but at a different level of depth and complexity. The elementary booklet tells stories. The middle booklet explains ideas. The high booklet argues and analyzes. The adult booklet engages with scholarly debates and primary sources. Read the one that fits — or read them all and watch the same figure grow.